

COPING WITH ADDICTION AND OTHER MEDICAL PROBLEMS # 20

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Understand the relationship between medical issues and addiction.
2. Reduce the impact of medical problems on recovery and relapse potential.
3. Reduce the risk of relapse by using therapeutic strategies to cope with both addictive problems and other illnesses or injuries.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE MEDICAL ISSUES

- Alternative Methods for Managing Pain
- Assessing My Needs
- Building My Support Network
- Coping with Addiction and Chronic Pain
- Coping with Stress
- Creating a Preliminary Health Plan
- Eating Patterns Self-Assessment
- Handling Crisis
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Learning to Self-Soothe
- Physical and Emotional Self-Care

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Coping with Addiction and Other Medical Problems” activity is designed for clients with, as the title indicates, serious medical problems apart from their addictive issues. It addresses issues of self-medication as a factor in addiction, the possible causal role of addictive behaviors in having suffered injuries or illnesses, and coping strategies to achieve the best practicable quality of life for these clients.

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Some people suffer from both substance abuse problems and other medical problems that may be very serious, even life-threatening. If you are working to recover from both an addiction and another dangerous or intensely painful medical problem, this assignment will help you use the same tools for both tasks where possible and guide you in coping with some special challenges in this situation.

1. What is the connection between addictions and other medical problems? Sometimes there is no connection. It's just coincidence or bad luck that the same person is both having a problem with alcohol, another drug, or an addictive behavior, and is also badly hurt or sick. However, it's also true that people who engage in addictive behaviors are much more likely than others to get hurt or sick, and people with debilitating injuries and illnesses are at higher-than-average risk to have problems with addictions. In some cases, people's injuries or illnesses are directly caused by their drinking, drug use, or other high-risk behavior (e.g., a heroin addict becoming infected with hepatitis C through a shared needle, a person contracting HIV from unsafe sex). This is not pointed out to blame anyone, but merely to acknowledge the role of cause and effect. Please describe any ways your addictive behavior caused or contributed to your becoming injured or ill.
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2. Sometimes the connection between addiction and medical issues works in the other direction. The medical problems come first, and then people medicate themselves for their pain or other symptoms—then they end up with addictions as well as the injuries or diseases they started with. When people use drugs (street drugs or prescription medications) to try to control or cope with their medical symptoms they may become dependent on those drugs. Please describe how your medical problems may have led you to addictive behaviors in the search for relief.
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3. If you know other people who have succeeded in recovering from both addictions and serious medical problems at the same time, can you understand how they did this? Could you use some of their methods? What did they do?
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4. Many people find that some of the same methods they use to overcome chemical dependence can also help them to deal with injuries or diseases that sharply limit their physical capabilities. These can be things like participating in support groups, learning new coping skills, and finding replacement methods and activities for things they can't do any more. What drug and alcohol recovery tools might help you deal with your own medical problems, and how would they help?

5. On the other hand, there are some treatment approaches used for medical problems that may seem not to fit into recovery from substance abuse, such as the use of narcotics and other powerful drugs for pain management. If you are under a doctor's instructions to take medications for your sickness or injury, have you talked about your substance abuse issues with the doctor who prescribed the medications? What did the doctor tell you about this?

6. What might happen to you and your recovery if you stopped taking those medications?

7. Have you also talked about this with people working with you on your addictive issues? What did these people tell you?

8. If you are participating in a 12-step recovery program, are you aware of the policies such programs have developed about the use of prescribed medications? What do you believe those programs have to say about this?

Actually, the official position of Alcoholics Anonymous is that if your doctor knows you are an alcoholic or addict and has prescribed medication with that knowledge, and you are taking it exactly as prescribed, you are doing what you need to do to stay sober. Other programs have similar policies. If any members of your 12-step group challenge this, they don't know their own program well enough. If you have questions, check what the official literature says.

9. Do you know others in a 12-step program who take powerful prescribed medications? How do they avoid falling into the trap of substance abuse?

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10. Please use this space to describe the tools, methods, and resources you will use to cope with the combined challenges of an addiction and a serious injury or illness.
